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EE/RPF

For use from May/November 2027

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Student personal code:

Extended essay - Reflection and progress form

Student: *This form is to be completed by you and your supervisor during the progress and completion of the extended essay. It records your progress through the extended essay process and includes your reflective statement addressing your extended essay experience. You must undertake three formal reflection sessions with your supervisor: The first formal reflection session should focus on your initial ideas and how you plan to undertake your research; the interim reflection session takes place once a significant amount of your research has been completed, and the final session will be in the form of a viva voce, once you have completed and handed in your extended essay. This document acts as a record in supporting the authenticity of your work. Following the viva voce, you write a* ***reflective statement*** *of no more than 500 words., which must be included on the RPF.*

The completion of this form is a mandatory requirement of the extended essay. It must be submitted together with the completed essay. The reflective statement will then be assessed under Criterion E. Students and supervisors should be aware that a mark of 0 will be awarded by the examiner for criterion E if the RPF is blank or the reflective statement is written in a language other than that of the accompanying essay.

Supervisor: *You must have three reflection sessions with each student, one early in the process, an interim meeting and then the final viva voce. Other check-in sessions are permitted but do not need to be recorded on this sheet. After each reflection session you must record the month that the reflection session took place, the student's year of DP study at that time and initial the form.*
By submitting this student work for assessment, you are taking responsibility for its authenticity. No piece of student work should be uploaded/submitted to the e-Coursework system if its authenticity is in doubt.

First reflection session

Month: June DP year (1 or 2): 1 Supervisor initials:

Interim reflection session

Month: October DP year (1 or 2): 2 Supervisor initials:

Final reflection session – Viva voce

Month: February DP year (1 or 2): 2 Supervisor initials:

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Reflective statement

(No more than 500 words, written in the same language as the accompanying extended essay)

I decided to write my EE about PayPal because I have a PayPal account, which is why I chose that case study. At first, I had other possible research questions, especially about opening and using a PayPal account when you are under 18: it is not allowed, but all my friends do it. But my supervisor advised me to steer away from this issue, for ethical reasons.

How did I benefit from the EE?

• It has helped me learn more about Business Management, for example benchmarking that I did not really understand until I studied what it means for Paypal. To use business tools beyond the guide, as instructed, I found two models online: VRIO (which is perfect to understand what makes a business unique like Paypal) and Porter's 5 Forces (the same business guru as the Generic Strategies).
• It gave me the chance to work on a big project – not just "big" for word count, but "big" in scope and planning, with several deadlines forcing you to plan small stages (it's like the relationship between "the overall aim" and "the small objectives" to reach that aim).
• As suggested by the librarian, I tried new tools: mind-mapping (doesn't work for me, I find it too confusing, it goes all over the place and has no structure), Gantt chart (inflexible and tabular but I like the visual and the principle) and my favorite: visual boards. I am proud of the one I created about PayPal and my EE, I wanted to include it here but it's not allowed. For the poster presentation, I used my visual board and explained the different components of my EE journey and my EE itself.

What could have been better?

• At first, I wasted time choosing my topic. I wanted it to do it on Paypal, but it is not easy to choose the question, it is not good to be told "formulate your own question". I can see why they do it, but as IB students, we are very busy and we can't waste time like this.
• I also wasted time with other business models (SWOT, STEEPLE, BCG) – in the end, my final EE only has VRIO and Porter's 5 Forces, but I had much more at some point – so I wrote more than 4000 words and had to discard so many parts.

What did I learn from this experience?

In fact I learnt about dealing with frustrations in a more mature way. This EE was an exercise of patience and ongoing dissatisfaction – not being allowed to select the question I wanted, hesitating between questions, wasting time applying business models that I later discarded, not going fast enough, going back, reviewing, revising, polishing it all. At first, I was annoyed at my supervisor for not guiding me more closely, but now I understand why he did not. The process was tough and I was too impatient, but now I love my EE, I love the final product.

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